

ENG510 SHORT HANDOUTS

MIDTERM

Lesson 06 to 10

(ENG510)Sociolinguistics

EFFORT BY VUHELPERS24 TEAM

REGARDS : SIR ZAHID: 03342743020

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Lesson 06

LANGUAGE CONTACT AND VARIATION- II

Topic 026: Variables and Variants

What is the example from Bequia that illustrates language variation?

Cheers and chairs in Bequia pronunciation.

Define the terms "variable" and "variant" in the context of studying language variation.

Variable is the abstract feature that varies, and variant is the actual instantiation of the variable in speech.

How can a variable be identified in linguistic analysis?

By convention, variables can be written in parentheses (e.g., (ear)) or referred to using key words.

Topic 027: Types of Variables and Variants

Explain the variation in the pronunciation of /p/ in English.

/p/ is pronounced differently based on its position within a word, with or without aspiration.

What are "allophones" in phonology, and how are they represented using the International Phonetic Alphabet (IPA)?

Allophones are phonetic variants of a phoneme. They are represented as [ph] for aspirated and [p] for unaspirated using IPA.

Compare the regularity of variation in /p/ in English to the variation in Bequian. Variation in /p/ in English is regular and predictable, whereas Bequian variation (NEAR class) is less precise and can vary within the same speaker.

Explain the variation in the pronunciation of the sound /p/ in English. How is this variation predictable?

The pronunciation of /p/ in English varies depending on its position within a word. At the start of a word, it is pronounced with clear aspiration (e.g., pinch). In contrast, at the end of a word (e.g., rap) or following an /s/ at the start of a word (e.g., speak), it is pronounced without aspiration. This variation is predictable and depends on the immediate linguistic context.

Topic 028: Synchronic Variation

Define synchronic linguistics and contrast it with diachronic linguistics.

Synchronic linguistics studies a language at a specific moment in time without considering its history, while diachronic linguistics examines language changes over time.

What aspects of language does synchronic variation in sociolinguistics focus on?

Synchronic variation explores grammar, syntax, semantics, and phonology at a single time point, considering different dialects and their features.

How can a synchronic study of English examine language variations?

By analyzing spelling differences, pronunciation, syntax, and vocabulary choices at a specific point in time.

What aspects of language are explored in synchronic variation in sociolinguistics, and how does it investigate dialects?

In synchronic variation in sociolinguistics, researchers explore language features at a single time point, including grammar, syntax, semantics, and phonology. This approach investigates various dialects and their features without referencing earlier or later stages.

Topic 029: Diachronic Variation

What is diachronic linguistics, and how does it differ from synchronic linguistics?

Diachronic linguistics studies language change over time, while synchronic linguistics focuses on a language at a specific moment.

Provide examples of diachronic linguistic changes in different linguistic levels (phonetic, phonemic, syntactic, semantic).

Examples include shifts in sounds, phonemes, syntax, and word meanings over time.

What is the significance of diachronic linguistics in understanding language?

Diachronic linguistics provides insights into language changes and patterns over time that cannot be discerned through synchronic analysis.

Define diachronic linguistics and explain its significance in understanding language.

Diachronic linguistics studies language change over time, examining shifts and mutations in language across different historical periods. It is essential for understanding how languages evolve and for tracing changes at various linguistic levels (e.g., phonetic, phonemic, morphological, syntactic, semantic).

Topic 030: Possibility of Predicting Language Change and Variation

Can linguists make accurate predictions about future linguistic developments? Why or why not?

Linguists generally cannot predict future linguistic developments due to the complexity of language change, including its random and unpredictable nature.

How does the "Uniformitarian Axiom" relate to predictions about linguistic change?

The Uniformitarian Axiom suggests that current principles in language will apply to future stages, but linguistic change often follows an S-shaped growth curve, not linear patterns.

What challenges exist in predicting language change, even when general principles are known?

Language change is influenced by internal, social, cognitive, and cultural factors, and unforeseen events can impact the direction and speed of change.

Explain the "Uniformitarian Axiom" in the context of predicting language change. How does it relate to predictions?

The Uniformitarian Axiom suggests that what is true in the present was also true in the past, and this principle is often used for predictions. However, linguistic change does not follow linear patterns, and the application of this axiom to the future may not yield accurate predictions. Instead, linguistic change often follows an S-shaped growth curve, as observed in the historical separation of modal verbs and the development of the progressive tense.

Lesson 07

SOME CONCEPTS RELATED TO LANGUAGE VARIETIES

Topic 031: Difference Between a Language and a Dialect

What cultural distinction do we make when using the terms 'language' and 'dialect'?

We make a cultural distinction between 'languages' and 'dialects.'

What influenced the distinction between 'language' and 'dialect' in English?

The distinction between 'language' and 'dialect' in English was influenced by Greek culture.

How do English speakers distinguish between a language and a dialect?

English speakers distinguish between a language and a dialect based on size and prestige.

How is the difference in size used to distinguish between a language and a dialect?

One way to distinguish between a language and a dialect is by the number of items they contain. A language contains more items than a dialect.

What is the role of prestige in distinguishing between a language and a dialect?

Prestige plays a role in distinguishing between a language and a dialect. Languages have prestige that dialects may lack.

Why do people in Britain often refer to unwritten varieties as dialects?

People in Britain often refer to unwritten varieties as dialects, irrespective of their linguistic status, based on their perception of prestige.

Topic 032: Some Examples of Dialects

What is a dialect, and how does it relate to a specific group of people?

A dialect is the language used by people in a specific area, class, district, or group of people.

How does George Bernard Shaw's "Pygmalion" illustrate the idea of dialect?

"Pygmalion" illustrates the idea of dialect by showing the difficulty in understanding a Cockney girl's language when she's adopted by a well-to-do gentleman.

How does Mark Twain use exaggerated dialect in "Huckleberry Finn" to distinguish between characters?

Mark Twain uses exaggerated dialect in "Huckleberry Finn" to distinguish between characters, such as Jim and Huck.

How does Harper Lee's "To Kill a Mockingbird" portray characters with less education and sophistication?

Characters with less education and sophistication in "To Kill a Mockingbird" are shown speaking with a much stronger dialect, often requiring translation to understand.

Topic 033: Standard Languages

What is a 'proper language' according to the text?

The only kind of variety that would count as a 'proper language' is a standard language.

How are standard languages created?

Standard languages are created through a deliberate intervention by society involving processes like selection, codification, elaboration of function, and acceptance.

What is the role of codification in standardizing a language?

Codification involves producing written dictionaries and grammar books to 'fix' the language, making everyone agree on what is correct.

What is the significance of a standard language once accepted by a population?

An accepted standard language becomes a strong unifying force for the state, a symbol of independence, and a marker of its difference from other states.

Topic 034: The Delimitation of Languages

How is mutual intelligibility used as a criterion for distinguishing languages?

If speakers of two varieties can understand each other, the varieties are considered instances of the same language; otherwise, they are not.

Why does popular usage sometimes label mutually intelligible varieties as different languages?

Popular usage often considers prestige when distinguishing languages. If two varieties are associated with different standards, they are seen as different languages.

What is a dialect continuum, and why is it significant?

A dialect continuum is a chain of mutually intelligible varieties. It's significant because it demonstrates that mutual intelligibility varies from total to none.

Does mutual intelligibility work as a reliable criterion for distinguishing languages based on size?

Mutual intelligibility doesn't work as a reliable criterion for distinguishing languages based on size, and there's no better alternative.

Topic 035: The Family Tree Model

What is the family tree model used for?

The family tree model is used to represent relationships among varieties and show how closely they are related to one another as a result of historical changes.

How does the family tree model treat the distinction between languages and dialects?

The family tree model makes no distinction between 'languages' and 'dialects,' and in historical linguistics, varieties descended from a common ancestor are often called 'dialects.'

What does the family tree model not consider, making it less useful for sociolinguists?

The family tree model does not consider one variety influencing another, which can lead to convergence, where a single variety descends from two separate varieties.

Lesson 08

LANGUAGE AND DIALECTS – I

Topic 036: Regional Dialects

What are regional dialects?

Regional dialects are linguistic variations based on geography.

What have dialectologists been studying since the 19th century in Europe and the United States?

Dialectologists have been studying the geographical distribution of linguistic items.

How do dialect geographers represent their results?

Dialect geographers represent their results by plotting them on a map.

What is the term used to describe the boundary for each area on a dialect map?

The term used is "isogloss."

According to the family tree model, what prediction can be made regarding isoglosses?

Isoglosses should not intersect.

Topic 037: Social Dialects

What are social dialects, and what factors contribute to them?

Social dialects refer to non-regional differences in language. Factors contributing to social dialects include social class, sex, and age.

In the context of social class and speech, what is unique about Britain compared to the United States and Germany?

In Britain, social class takes precedence over geography as a determinant of speech, leading to more geographical variation among lower social classes. This is not the case in the United States or Germany.

What distinguishes between standard dialect and non-standard dialects in the context of pronunciation?

Standard dialect is related to vocabulary, syntax, and morphology, while pronunciation is expressed in accents.

Topic 038: Idiolects

What is an idiolect?

An idiolect is the unique set of speech habits and linguistic characteristics of an individual.

How does an idiolect differ from a dialect?

An idiolect is unique to an individual, while a dialect is a common set of linguistic characteristics shared among a group of people.

What criticism exists regarding the concept of idiolects?

Some criticisms include the idea that idiolects do not exist, are useless, or incoherent.

What factors contribute to the uniqueness of an individual's idiolect?

Factors like living in different locations at different ages, unique family terms, specific jargon from schools and workplaces, and other languages spoken can contribute to the uniqueness of an idiolect.

Define idiolect and explain how it differs from a dialect.

An idiolect is the unique set of speech habits and linguistic characteristics specific to an individual. It encompasses the individual's vocabulary, grammar, and pronunciation. Idiolects differ from dialects, which are shared sets of linguistic characteristics among groups of people. While dialects represent a collective, idiolects are personal and unique to each person.

Topic 039: Dialects and Identity

How does linguistic identity relate to who we are?

Linguistic identity is connected to our sense of belonging and is shaped by our identity.

What role do dialects play in expressing identity?

Dialects can be used to express one's identity, and the choice of how to speak is influenced by one's sense of belonging.

Topic 040: Study of Dialects in Sociolinguistics

What is dialectology, and how does it relate to sociolinguistics?

Dialectology is the scientific study of linguistic dialect, a sub-field of sociolinguistics. It studies variations in language based on geographic distribution.

How can major native dialects of English be categorized?

Major native dialects of English can be categorized into three general categories: British Isles dialects, North American dialects, and Australasian dialects.

What are the key principles regarding the study of dialects?

The key principles include the descriptive nature of linguistics, the systematic nature of language varieties, and the focus on speech over writing in linguistics.

What are the three general categories of major native dialects of English, and how do they differ?

Major native dialects of English can be categorized into three general categories: British Isles dialects, North American dialects, and Australasian dialects. These dialects differ based on their regional origins and exhibit variations in pronunciation, vocabulary, spelling, and grammar.

What are the key principles that underlie the study of dialects in linguistics?

There are several key principles regarding the study of dialects in linguistics. First, linguistics is descriptive rather than prescriptive, meaning it aims to describe language usage rather than prescribe how it should be used. Second, every naturally used language variety is systematic, with regular rules and restrictions at the lexical, phonological, and grammatical levels. The term 'dialect' is used neutrally to refer to systematic usage by a group of speakers, without negative connotations. Third, the primary focus is on speech rather than writing when studying dialects, as it reflects the real usage of language by speakers.

Lesson 09

LANGUAGE AND DIALECTS – II

Topic 041: Language and Dialect in Papua New Guinea

How many languages are spoken in Melanesia, including Papua New Guinea?

Up to 1,500 languages are spoken in Melanesia, with as many as half found in Papua New Guinea alone.

What is betelnut, and how is it used in Papua New Guinea?

Betelnut is a small green nut of the betel palm, chewed with lime pepper. It's typically spat out after chewing.

How many major language families are recognized in Papua New Guinea?

Linguists generally recognize two major language families in Papua New Guinea: Austronesian and non-Austronesian (Papuan).

What are some factors that contribute to linguistic diversity in Papua New Guinea?

Factors include the long history of human habitation, rugged terrain creating physical barriers, and cultural attitudes fostering and maintaining diversity.

Can you describe the linguistic diversity in Melanesia, specifically in Papua New Guinea?

Melanesia, which includes Papua New Guinea, is incredibly diverse linguistically. It encompasses up to 1,500 languages, with nearly half of them found in Papua New Guinea alone. Most of these languages are spoken by small groups, and approximately 40 percent have fewer than 500 speakers. This linguistic diversity extends to a variety of language types within the region.

What is the significance of the use of betelnut in Papua New Guinea, and how do people use it?

Betelnut is a small green nut of the betel palm, and it holds cultural importance in Papua New Guinea. It is typically chewed with lime pepper, which turns the mouth a bright reddish-orange. After chewing, it is spat out. It is often used as a means of social interaction and a cultural tradition.

Topic 042: Language and Dialect in Europe

What is a dialect continuum?

A dialect continuum is a situation where mutually intelligible dialects exist between adjacent regions, despite differences between standard languages.

In Scandinavia, what allows for communication across language boundaries?

Danish, Swedish, and Norwegian are closely related languages, making it possible for travelers to communicate across language boundaries.

How has political history influenced the perception of separate languages in Scandinavia?

Political history and standardization efforts have led to the perception of Danish, Swedish, and Norwegian as separate languages, despite their linguistic similarity.

Can you explain the concept of a dialect continuum and provide examples from Europe?

A dialect continuum is a situation where mutually intelligible dialects exist between adjacent regions, despite differences between standard languages. In Europe, a classic example is the West Romance dialect continuum, stretching from the Atlantic coast of France through Italy, Spain, and Portugal. Mutual intelligibility exists between adjacent villages, although speakers of the standard varieties of French, Italian, Spanish, and Portuguese may find one another mutually unintelligible to varying degrees.

Topic 043: Language and Dialects in Africa

What factors contribute to linguistic diversity in Cameroon?

Cameroon's colonial history (German, French, British rule) has led to the coexistence of French and English as official languages, with multiple indigenous languages spoken.

How do people in Cameroon handle linguistic diversity in their daily lives?

People often use a local lingua franca (English) for communication when their mother tongues differ, and written text in the official languages (French and English) unifies the diversity.

Topic 044: Language and Dialects in Pakistan

What are the official languages of Pakistan?

The official languages of Pakistan are Urdu and English, with Urdu being the national language.

How does linguistic diversity manifest within Pakistan?

Pakistan is home to various regional languages, such as Punjabi, Baluchi, Sindhi, and Pashto, with different dialects and speech forms within each language.

Topic 045: Language in Society

What is the reciprocal relationship between language and social interaction?

Language shapes social interactions, and social interactions, in turn, shape language. This relationship is at the core of sociolinguistics.

What are some factors that cause language variation within a speech community?

Language variation is influenced by factors like the nature of participants, their relationship, the number of participants, roles of participants, function of speech events, medium, genre of discourse, and physical setting.

What are the key factors that cause language variation within a speech community, and how does this variation manifest in different contexts?

Language variation within a speech community is influenced by various factors, including the nature of participants, their relationships, the number of participants, roles in speech events, function, medium, genre of discourse, and physical setting. These factors lead to variations in language based on age, sex, social class, occupation, and cultural group, affecting both geographical and social space.

Lesson 10

SOME THEORETICAL WORK IN SOCIOLINGUISTICS

Topic 046: Regional Dialectology

What is regional dialectology?

The identification and mapping of boundaries among different language varieties in specific regions.

How do dialectologists document language variation in regions?

They use methods like collecting vocabulary items and noting local pronunciation through surveys.

What is the significance of the nineteenth century in regional dialectology?

It saw the initiation of large projects to study regional language variation, like the Atlas Linguistique de la France.

What challenges do dialectologists face in their methods?

They depend on speakers' reports, which may not be entirely accurate.

What are some challenges associated with the methods used in regional dialectology?

There are two primary challenges. First, these methods heavily rely on speakers' self-reports of their speech, which may not always be accurate. Second, people may not accurately report what they actually say, which can affect the reliability of the data collected.

Topic 047: The Work of Labov

Who is William Labov?

A prominent figure in American linguistics known for pioneering variationist sociolinguistics.

What is the central doctrine of variationist sociolinguistics?

That linguistic variation is inherent to linguistic structure.

What distinguishes Labov's approach within sociolinguistics?

His reliance on quantitative methods and the study of patterns of linguistic variation.

What are some of Labov's notable works?

"The Social Stratification of English in New York City" and "The Atlas of North American English."

What are some key areas of Labov's research?

Labov has examined phonological, semantic, and grammatical features in English, with a focus on phonological variation. He has conducted influential studies on American dialectology, particularly in New York City, and African American Vernacular English (AAVE).

Topic 048: Martha's Vineyard

Where was the first social dialect study conducted in 1961?

Martha's Vineyard, an island off the coast of Massachusetts.

What is a key variable that William Labov observed on Martha's Vineyard?

The realization of diphthongs in words like "ice" and "time."

How did Labov collect data on language variation on the Vineyard?

He conducted sociolinguistic interviews with residents.

What did Labov find out about the variation on Martha's Vineyard?

That it was not free variation but had social, occupational, and regional factors.

What was the main finding of Labov's study on Martha's Vineyard?

Labov discovered that variations in pronunciation were not free but were influenced by factors such as social identity. Fishermen, for example, exhibited

distinctive centralization of certain diphthongs as a way to establish their identity as Vineyarders.

Topic 049: Developments in the Study of Language Variation

What is Biber's multi-feature/multi-dimensional (MF/MD) analysis framework?

A framework for analyzing language variation that considers multiple linguistic features and their functional aspects.

What are the general characteristics of the MF/MD analysis approach?

Corpus-based, uses computational techniques, quantitative, and synthesizes quantitative and functional methods.

How does the MF/MD approach link form and function in language analysis?

It establishes a connection between linguistic features and their functional roles.

Topic 050: Further Insights into the Study of Language Variation

What did Hyland study regarding meta-discourse in textbooks and research articles?

He compared the features of meta-discourse in introductory textbooks and research articles in different academic disciplines.

What did Hyland find regarding the importance of metadiscourse in textbooks?

There were an average of 405 examples per text, about one every 15 words.

What did Kachru explore using a small corpus?

The use of definite reference across regional varieties of English in different parts of the world.

How did Kachru collect data for his study?

He used letters to the editor from newspapers in India, Nigeria, Singapore, and the USA.

Working on the Next Lessons

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